

FLT Process Addendum v01

Purpose: This addendum records process lessons learned from the Philippians 1 trial. It should guide Philippians 2 and future chapters until these principles are fully integrated into the Style Guide, Glossary, and Translation Packet Template.

1. First-Read Clarity Principle

FLT aims for first-read understanding.

The steering question is:

Can a first-time reader understand this on the first read without losing the Greek meaning?

When a more literal rendering communicates clearly, use it. When a more literal rendering leaves the target reader confused, uncertain, or forced to reread several times, FLT may move from “what it says” toward “what it means.”

2. Minimum Departure as a Brake

The minimum-departure principle remains important, but it is a brake, not the steering wheel.

It prevents unnecessary paraphrase. It does not require FLT to stay close to formal English when formal English fails first-read understanding.

The working question is not:

How close can we stay to the Greek form?

The working question is:

What is the clearest natural English that faithfully carries the Greek meaning, logic, tone, and theological force?

3. GREEN / YELLOW / RED Workflow

Each unit or verse should be triaged before full review.

GREEN — Clear enough

No major Greek issue, no first-read confusion. Accept with light polish.

YELLOW — Needs a decision

One or two wording issues need review. Use Clarity Translator and Greek Guardian, then let the human editor decide.

RED — Slow down

Dense theology, major metaphor, key term, ambiguity, or first-read failure. Use the fuller process: model review, human wrestling, possible target-reader test, and decision-log entry.

4. Target Reader Stylist

A target reader may serve as a Readability Stylist.

The stylist may flag:

- awkward word order
- unclear referents
- sentences that are too long
- stiff or unnatural words
- phrases that do not make sense on first read
- repeated words that sound accidental

Stylist changes may be accepted freely when they improve oral clarity without changing meaning.

If a stylist change may shift meaning, run a changed-lines-only Greek check.

5. Changed-Lines-Only Greek Check

Do not reopen an entire passage when only a few lines changed.

For stylist edits, check only:

1. Does the change preserve the Greek meaning?
2. Does it undo a logged decision?
3. Does it create new ambiguity?
4. Does it improve first-read clarity?

If the answer is acceptable, move forward.

6. Footnote and Study-Layer Principle

The reading view should stay clean. It should not become a study Bible.

However, when the body text moves from “what it says” to “what it means,” or when a key term carries important meaning that cannot fit naturally in the body text, use a brief footnote or study-view note.

The reading text serves comprehension.
The study layer serves accountability.

7. Plural “You” Policy

Do not mark every singular or plural “you” in the reading text.

When singular/plural distinction matters for clarity, render it naturally:

- all of you
- you all
- each of you
- both of you
- your whole group
- among you

In the study/interlinear view, mark second-person pronouns as singular or plural consistently.

8. Stopping Rule

A unit may be marked provisionally complete when:

1. no major Greek meaning is knowingly lost,
2. the target reader can understand the main point,
3. the human editor can explain the decision,
4. major decisions are logged,
5. remaining issues can wait for read-aloud, footnotes, or study notes.

The goal is defensible progress, not exhausted perfection.

9. Philippians 1 Precedents

Philippians 1 established several working precedents:

- “good news” for εὐαγγέλιον
- “God’s holy people” for ἅγιοι
- “leaders and assistants” for ἐπίσκοποι and διάκονοι in Phil 1:1
- “servants” for δοῦλοι, with a footnote explaining belonging, obligation, and willing service
- “deliverance” for σωτηρία where release, vindication, and final rescue may all be in view
- “govern yourselves” for πολιτεύεσθε in Phil 1:27
- “reflects the true value” for ἀξίως where “worthy” might imply earning
- “competing together as one team” for συναθλοῦντες
- “to stay faithful to the good news” for τῇ πίστει τοῦ εὐαγγελίου in context
- “all of this is from God” for broad neuter τοῦτο reference in Phil 1:28

10. Instruction for Models

When reviewing future FLT passages, do not rewrite everything by default.

First identify:

1. Must-fix issues
2. Optional polish
3. First-read clarity problems
4. Greek meaning at risk
5. Places where the current wording is already good enough

Only propose a full rewrite when the passage is RED or the current draft fails.